

RED ELYDE



VOICES FOR SOCIALIST REPUBLICANISM

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PAY WHAT YOU CAN

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EDITORIAL LINE

Red Clyde is a news service for working class people across Glasgow and the Clyde Valley.

Our name, 'Red Clyde' was inspired by the Red Clydeside movement in Glasgow, a period of left-wing political radicalism in Glasgow from 1910 to 1930. Red Clydeside was rooted in working class anti-war movements, rent strikes, industrial action and solidarity with the Irish Republican movement.

With more than a hundred years since Glaswegians forced the British State to send tanks to George Square in fear of a Scottish socialist revolution, the greed of bosses and landlords has only grown more and more staggering. Across the world, workers are becoming increasingly politically active as the US-led world order is decaying. We plan to contribute to this activity by clarifying the problems we face here and uniting with our fellow workers with practical analysis.

All nations and peoples have a right to self-determination; Scotland is not outwith this. We uphold a Scottish Socialist Republican perspective as we believe that true freedom and democracy for the workers in Scotland can only be achieved by an independent worker's state. One that is free from the political domination of England and free from international capitalist economic control through democratic worker ownership.



INTRODUCING RED CLYDE

Imperialism's depravity grows day by day in its attempts to stifle the resistance and rebelliousness of the oppressed peoples of the world. We understand that media is one part of this battle. The capitalists class with its media apparatus tries to confuse, distract, and lie to us. From whipping up racist hatred, media blackouts of revolutionary struggles, to genocide apologia, the currently existing media serves the rich through pitting us against each other and hiding (or lying about!) the truth. They portray a bleak world with no chance of working class liberation.

In opposition, we firmly plant the Saltire and the red flag of socialism. We understand the role of working class media to be in the service of the struggle. We will expose our enemies, uplift our class and show the world as it is. A world brimming with revolutionary struggle, from the forests of Dandakaranya, the streets of Jenin, to our very own Glasgow.

We aim to go beyond writing and publishing political articles, rather, we run this whole project politically. We choose to be unfunded, we choose to not credit anyone in our team, we choose to write from within the struggle, not as observers, but as active participants making revolution.

Through our work, we hope to illuminate the growing Socialist Republican movement, the necessity of an independent socialist Scotland, and to proactively build our solidarity with all oppressed people here and across the world.

We have seen the struggle for the national liberation of Scotland be dominated by electoralists who cannot envision a strategy beyond asking Westminster for another referendum. This strategy has failed to deliver us independence. The Westminster regime has clarified its intention to never grant a second referendum. It is beyond time to agitate for an independence movement beyond the confines of Holyrood and Westminster.

Through highlighting the struggles taken on by the working class, from tenants, hospitality workers, railway workers and many more, we hope to show that we alone can liberate Scotland with our own hands.

In our first issue, we interviewed socialist artist Keira McLean and reviewed her new play *Fire Stories*. Regarding domestic news, we tackle the Commonwealth Games, which are happening again in Glasgow. We also have a piece on the recent national election and the prospects of the independence movement today. Internationally, we focus on South-West Asia, primarily the Lebanese state's surrender agreement. We are also releasing the first part of a series on the war between Iran and the US.

We appreciate any comments and feedback. Please send them to our email: **redclyde@proton.me**

THE ALL TOO COMMON GAMES: *First as a tragedy, now as a farce*



Image shows Glasgow's 2026 Commonwealth Games mascot Finny The Proud Unicorn.

The Commonwealth Games are coming back to Glasgow after only a short 12 years. The 2014 edition of the Games was a fiasco and a disaster for ordinary people. Ranging from the bulldozing of a day centre for disabled people to replace it with a bus park, the handing over of £17 million pounds of council money for the purchase of the land for the Emirates Arena, to the building of the Athletes Village in Dalmarnock, where only 20% of the 1500 homes are social housing – considering the housing demolitions, this meant only 103 new social homes.

It would be reasonable to think that after this mess that Glasgow shouldn't be hosting the Commonwealth Games again, at least until the council got its shit together and worked for the people of the city. But, to our unpleasant surprise, Glasgow City Council [GCC] took on the hosting of the Games in 2024, giving them two short years to prepare to host athletes from 74 countries!

Before we go into further detail, we at Red Clyde aren't city planners nor have we ever hosted hundreds of people from around the world. However, when you have friends come over, you ensure that it's tidy and ready to welcome people. You don't host your friends when mid deep-cleaning the bathroom. Clearly, the fine folk at the council don't know basic hosting as they'll be welcoming these world class athletes to our daily sight of a mess of a city centre. With a dug up George Square, unusable roads for public transport, and more derelict buildings than ever. We are lucky, in a way, as hundreds of international guests will get to see the real Glasgow – GCC failed in sprucing it up.

This situation is almost comedic. The council is not content with ripping off its own people, with them reaching into the pockets of Victoria, all the way in Australia, who cancelled hosting due to the price tag. For this, they've been punished with a AUS\$380 million fine, with 200 (around £100 million) of that being sent to GCC. GCC ripping off taxpayers from Glasgow to Melbourne. It's almost impressive!

This wasn't enough for GCC. They initially wished to hold a world-class sporting tournament without spending a penny, however, they have backtracked since the initial announcement. GCC, sportscotland, and the Scottish Government are all contributing £250,000 to a total of £1.25 million. Is this really the wisest decision when our public infrastructure is decaying, when buildings are collapsing regularly and when the cultural life of the city is so squeezed?

We have to ask, will these games even be remembered by the participants and by us? We remember the first Games for the tragic harm it brought our city,. This time, they are so devoid of anything that we will all forget about it a day or two after it is finished.

Fundamentally, we have to question the premise of the Commonwealth Games. A sporting event for all the countries colonised by the British State is absurd. The SNP choosing to host it shows their hypocrisy. Independence can't just be decided in one referendum, it needs to be a guiding principle for every societal decision. Hosting the Commonwealth Games is certainly not conducive towards building a genuine republican alternative and fostering an energetic independence movement.

*‘Heat, fuel n oxygen as well
That’s aw a fire needs tae
ignite itsel’*



Keira McLean, *The Fire That Never Went Out*, 2026 Film still
Credit: Caireen Stuart

Easterhouse Fire Stories



FIRE STORIES AND CARRIER BAGS

Fire Stories Easterhouse is a multi-media performance that tells the radical histories of Easterhouse, Glasgow. The project was created by Keira McLean in collaboration with the Red Flag Players and Easterhouse residents.

The Craiggallian fire is said to have burned for twenty years. It was kept lit in service of rovers and wanderers and those without hearth. Fire was one of our first technologies, another one was the basket, the net, the sack. Vessels for carrying things. The Carrier Bag Theory of Fiction is a literary concept by Ursula K. Le Guin. It proposes that the first tool was not a killing weapon, not a spear, knife or cudgel. Rather it was a vessel to hold gathered food. It theorises that stories should function as vessels holding multiple narratives and experiences.

It argues against the narrative of the Killer Hero, whose stories are always linear and driven by conflict. In the Heroes journey the Hero goes out into the world. He (and it is typically a He) struggles and ultimately triumphs. The story goes in a straight line like a killing spear. In and out. It's a good and simple story, it satisfies the prevailing arc of history, conflict, violence and conquest.

Le Guin's Carrier bag instead, holds the messiness of everyday life. It's not concerned with an individual's narrative, but with the collective. It gathers stories, songs, characters, communities, details and vagaries. Every narrative is valued as equal to the next. Holding them all in space together, allowing for connections between these elements. It matters what stories we tell and who does the telling. It matters what we choose to gather.

I walk through a street lined with tight bricked yellow houses; kids shriek in the distance. The football is on and the city feels restless. In the Glenburn Centre my ticket link up is not linking but the woman with the lists lets me in anyway. Thank you angel lady! Thank you imminent weeping!

In the hall the rafters are hung with Scottish flags for the game tonight. There are billboards with pictures of community events, bingo nights and after school clubs. The performers are dressed up in matching reds and dancing haphazardly in the middle of two aisles of chairs. A woman plays the guitar and sings. I expected teenagers somehow, but the cast is multi-generational. In the stage area there are models of rocks around a paper fire. Handmade art is everywhere. A paper collage at the head of the stage with cut outs from the socialist newspaper 'The Voice'. The red fabric flag draped around a player's shoulder.

A red print says:
'I lit the fire, I lit the fire'

Another says
'I gifted this land to you'
Of which I am unsure. Who is gifting the land to who? But perhaps I'm just pedantic.

A woman twists in her chair and offers me a biscuit. Thank you imminent weeping.



The players take their seats around the fire and begin the performance. You could describe it as a radical panto. You could describe it as a bag holding stories and small burning fires- interweaving, dance, video, song and story in a net. The players say- This is a story of Easterhouse, but it's also a story of Glasgow- of The World.

A woman sings a work song.

The first story is of a woman who came from China to study nursing. She talks about her mother's water pipe. Battery powered fire light springs from the paper hearth. The fire sitters poke it with long sticks. Flame sounds play from the speakers. The players speak about various fires.

The cast take us through Easterhouse's history. After WWII huge numbers of residents were moved out of slum tenements and into housing schemes, such as Easterhouse with the promise of light, heat, and indoor plumbing. The council however, had neglected to provide basic amenities, effectively stranding the people there. Historically, working-class people have been at the forefront of every effort to revitalise the area.

There is a song about carers to the tune of if it wissnae fer your wellies where would you be.

A fire sitter tells us the stories of woman who were barred from practising midwifery.

Another tells us about a community workers campaign against damp conditions in housing with the help of a giant model breeze block.

We hear about the old fight of the people against a council that has abandoned them again and again.

A video plays slightly out of sight. The child of the biscuit giver walks along the top of a row of chairs visiting people in the audience he knows.

The performance being held in this space in the heart of Easterhouse has this thematic resonance. Community run spaces like the Glenburn Centre would have been the site of the action and organising the performance describes. The centre feels like an active stage set. The site anchors the performance in the place its set in, bringing the audience into the community. De-centring (literally) the 'Art Spaces' that Glasgow International events are usually held in.

There are sort of two performances happening at once. The stories from the fire sitters – personal, introspective, lightly rambling. Interwoven with the theatrics of the players who push the narrative along. The performance is camp, it's a wink and a middle finger. It's also a lot of information presented in as many ways possible, accompanied by a music hall 'Oh no it isn't! Oh yes it is!' This could be twee, I think. But it resists it. It looks twee right in the eye and shrugs. Twee is accessible. The tone slides between the real lived experiences of the fire sitters and the players performances.



The layers of stories build up and form a picture of Easterhouse, a mesh formed of multiple interwoven narratives cut and pasted together. What I like best are the edges. Keira clutches a woman's hand after she does her part. People clap each other on the back as they stand up to speak. The good will the players have for each other infects the audience; there is a warmth in the room.

I think about the Craigallian fire. Which was a fire for everyone. How simple but impossible that feels. How could you possibly maintain a fire without letting it go out. How do you tend it? How do you protect it from the rain and wind? For twenty years! How did people even know to do it? People showing up in this way now feels like a fantasy. The scale of the community organising the performers describe seems like an improbable fairytale. Like a myth of community.

Fire Stories presents an urgent counter narrative to political nihilism. Story telling is world building. Story telling is a radical act. If the only story you hear about the place you live is that it's a place no one wants to be. What effect does that have on a community? Fire Stories is a fuck you to that narrative. It says there's life here, there's culture here.

Back at the start of the performance the players spoke about fires that you could carry in vessels.

Starting a fire from scratch involves a lot of labour. It requires dry tinder, skill and good weather conditions. In an inhospitable environment fire starting can be challenging. The solution was to carry fire, transporting a living ember during travel that could be kindled at the next camp. You could carry your fire in a bundle of bark and green leaves. Insulating the ember while the moisture in the green leaves kept from igniting. You could store it in a piece of fungus. People would carry embers and tinder in bison horns. They used rolls of bark like cigars packed with soft rotted wood.

Le Guin says:

'I would go so far as to say that the natural, proper, fitting shape of the novel might be that of a sack, a bag. A book holds words. Words hold things. They bear meanings. A novel is a medicine bundle, holding things in a particular, powerful relation to one another and to us.'



Image of King Alfreds Cake Fungus used to carry embers for fire lighting.

<https://www.wildharvestuk.net/>

‘I don’t want people to get the idea that we’re there to “help” the community.

We are in the community offering skills and facilitation to very capable, amazing community members who have been fighting their entire lives.

We are only helping to put a spotlight on these marginalised and neglected histories.’

THE FIRE STILL BURNS:
AN INTERVIEW WITH
KEIRA MCLEAN



THE FIRE STILL BURNS: AN INTERVIEW WITH KEIRA MCLEAN

This interview was conducted with Keira McLean on the 10th of June leading up the debut of *Fire Stories*. For a review of the play, please read *Fire Stories and Carrier Bags*

RC: Who are you?

KM: I'm an artist and activist from Glasgow. I make stained glass windows, I do workers theatre. I do a lot of community arts, I've been involved in various campaigns over many years, including as a member of RIC [Radical Independence Campaign] and Castlemilk Against Austerity. I've worked a lot with women-led organisations up in Castlemilk, in anti-food poverty initiatives. Now I work a lot in schemes in Glasgow and Fife, engaging communities in political literacies through creative practice.

RC: What are you doing?

KM: I'll start at the beginning, two and a half years ago I became obsessed with a piece of Scottish radical working class history centred around the Craigallian Fire which was a radical campfire that existed in the 1920s just outside Milngavie. The story is that the fire burned continuously for 20 years, so I've written a play about it and the people that sat around it, its called *The Fire that Never Went Out*.

'The question we're asking does the Craigallian Fire still burn? Could you have a Craigallian Fire today? What's our relationship with land and access to the outdoors? The fire itself became this destination, a radical hotspot,'

As we were developing it, somebody I knew wrote a wee song for it, and we started to perform little bits of the piece and I became really interested in it with folk who knew about the fire, knowing people who had sat there and it grew and grew in my mind. It developed into a workers theatre project, as well as a social history project.

The question we're asking does the Craigallian Fire still burn? Could you have a Craigallian Fire today? What's our relationship with land and access to the outdoors? The fire itself became this destination, a radical hotspot, it wasn't just a pit-stop for hillwalkers. Communists met there, radical midwives met there, the Carbeth huts grew out of it, international brigaders who went off and fought Franco sat around it, some of them never came back. Land reforms sat there. It became a hotspot for the west coast of Scotland and Red Clydeside's radical history.

I've always been looking for a reference to John Maclean, I'm convinced he would have walked there. The only link I've found to John Maclean is that Bob Greave, a famous firesitter, became an urban planner and was a big proponent of loch Lomond becoming a national park. Bob Greave's mum was one of two women allowed to bring John Maclean his food in prison, she was also a firesitter. So I reckon Maclean would've visited the fire, but there's no record of it unfortunately.

We also wanted this to be a piece of political education. Bringing these radical histories and learning about them can serve as beacons of hope and action for today's struggle, that's really the point of examining working class history. We decided what would be nice that in each performance of the play – we have never shown the play in its entirety before – is that the final scene would tell the radical history of the place we're performing. And that's really what *Fire Stories* became. For some bizarre reason we got a budget to do that part, we contacted loads of official organisations and people in positions in these institutions weren't interested in the stories, but we found that ordinary people are very interested in it and are actually hungry for political theatre and for political art because there isn't any.

So we've been collecting an audience, a network of supporters, artists have joined, we are now a merry band of 15, a loose collective with a core group of 6 making this play. For the past 6 months we've received a little bit of funding from Creative Scotland after two and a half years of trying to get some and some support from GI with funding and some other things. Basically we were told "what do you wanna do, right let's produce the last scene, let's tell the radical histories of Easterhouse in a play form", and what's happened is that it's become three things at once. It's a play in its own right, it is the last scene of a wider play, it's also a template for how to make a piece of community engaged art. We are making it with local people from Easterhouse, many of these people are legends in the community, they have been fighting for their community their whole lives. They are community leaders and have been politically active.

I don't want people to get the idea that we're there to "help" the community. We are in the community offering skills and facilitation to very capable, amazing community members who have been fighting their entire lives. We are only helping to put a spotlight on these marginalised and neglected histories.

RC: Why Easterhouse?

KM: Easterhouse made sense. There is an institution, Platform, that has been very helpful. It was decided that our first full production will occur in Easterhouse. It is also somewhere that I've been working for five years. I've worked with lots of different community groups, I've made a stained glass window there. So people trust me. This is also a new venture for me. This is the first piece of theatre I've ever made. In order to make that piece of theatre well I'm learning. It's great to have a group that trust and know you, and who are actually friends.

These people that I'm working with, they're not just members of a group, they're my comrades and friends. We know about each others lives – those lines are blurred. That does often happen when you work in communities long term and it certainly should because my whole thing is that you're not just there as a tutor, you're there also to learn. That relationship is reciprocal, there is something fundamental about my practice that's about exchange. You're not parachuting in, you're not extracting cultural and creative labour from communities, although there is a part of that. They are providing their labour and creativity, but you are in turn providing skills, access to knowledge they might not have, access to opportunities and resources they might not have. That has to be a fundamental part of your community practice.



A lot of artists come out of art school – I didn't go to art school, I'm self-taught, I went to college and learnt how to do architectural stained glass, but everything else is through an interest in reading and an interest in radical pedagogical practice, that kind of thing. Too many young artists come out and parachute in and they'll say "oh it's up to the community". No, you have resources and privileges that folk don't have, you need to share that and come in with some degree of a plan at least. You can't just extract creative labour from folk without giving something back. That's what we are all about.

RC: Why did you choose theatre? Do you have a background in theatre?

KM: I love theatre, Alain Badiou says theatre is politics in action and I kind of agree with that. I come from a visual arts background – I make stained glass windows – , so I started exhibiting and doing different things. I got fed up with that white cube way of doing things, I found it boring. We started theming our shows and we found people who wanted to work the way we do, so we wanted to try new things. I've tried out loads of different things with different collectives over the years, such as magazines, albums. We started putting on these much more theatrical style gigs and nights. I've been working a lot with Glasgow rappers and radical poets and that all morphed into a much more theatrical way of delivering material. Suddenly here we are, I've written a play and now we're developing workers theatre.

Through all that I've been a student of radical political art, especially in this city. I'm very influenced by Workers City and their interventions, but also Test Dept, big heroes of mine, I also love the Situationists. It was really about bringing all of that into my own practice, and I ended up here. There's no straight line or road map, it's just something that happened.

'How we make it is really more important than what we end up with. How we've done it is through collaboration and co-ownership with Easterhouse residents, who were already engaged with the history of Easterhouse and had taken part in the political and radical action through its history.'

I have no professional theatrical experience, our whole thing is that we're DIY, for instance, when we put on our play, we use archive film. We've created new archive films because we have an archive film-maker in our collective. We did that because we had no knowledge about lighting. We are using the skills we already have and are making a play based on those skills.

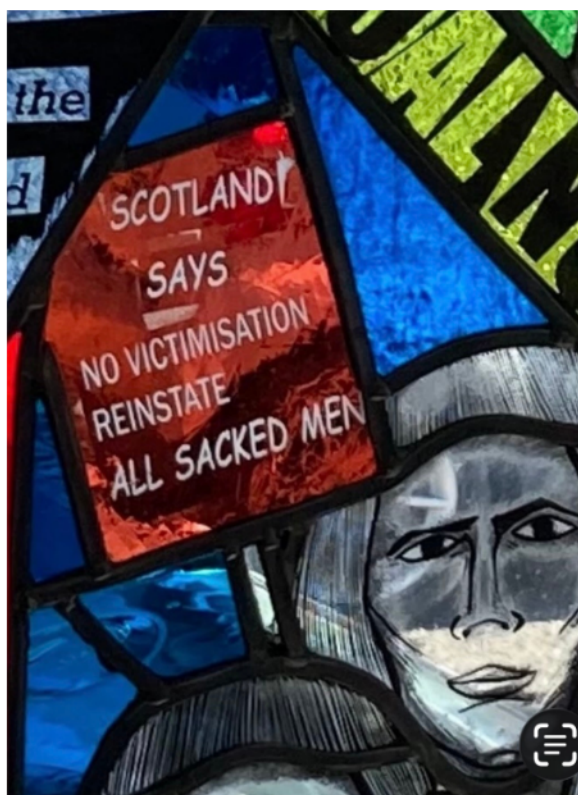
So no to theatre background, but we are gaining experience as we go. We are listening to our gut advice as well and using the skills we already have. People are joining all the time, offering support and helping guide us. This isn't just performance, we're building a movement and that's really exciting.

RC: How did you make it?

KM: How we make it is really more important than what we end up with. How we've done it is through collaboration and co-ownership with Easterhouse residents, who were already engaged with the history of Easterhouse and had taken part in the political and radical action through its history.

Basically we set a period of research visiting local archives, film screenings, all of that as a group. Throughout every visit there was discussion, what did we find, what did we learn? People were creating journal entries based on these visits. We were meeting every week for 6 months, we then did some creative writing sessions with different artists, then letter-writing sessions, we worked with 9 working class artists throughout the process who were also performers in the play. We did some animation workshops, we've also made a new archive film. The animations were made by us based on our research and materials collected from the archive. So every step has involved the group, we've discussed it together, we've acted as a creative ensemble throughout the process and I think that's why when we began folk were like I'm not going to be in it, and now folk are asking for more lines. Everyone is in it, it feels like a family. Some of the feedback we've had has been amazing.

It's about that process and journey. How you make political art matters as much as the art that you make.



RC: Anything else you'd like to share?

KM: What's really great about this is where it's going to be on. It's going to be held at the Glenburn Centre, which is a community centre attached to Easthall Resident Association, which was Cathy McCormack's housing association, she in part helped build that community. We are debuting our performance where she debuted her play *The Damp Busters*. That feels really special, a lot of the people in our crew have met Cathy, I myself have had the privilege of meeting her. That feels really special and important.

This isn't for a middle class audience, it's for everyone, but for people in the community first and foremost. It's their story. The idea is that GI audiences want to come to it, they need to travel out of the city centre, out of their comfort zone and visit Easterhouse and see the real Glasgow. We've had a bit of an offer to take it to Springburn to their community and show it to them. We want to take it from scheme to scheme and build this alternative theatre telling these neglected and radical histories of these schemes. Because that's the real Glasgow.

FURTHER RESOURCES:

Workers City Archive:

<https://www.workerscity.org/>

Test Dept: <https://testdept.org.uk/history>

Holyrood or Independence?

Election Aftermath Shows Once Again Holyrood's Path to Independence is a Dead-End



A Scottish independence rally in Glasgow on 11 January 2020. Photograph: Andy Buchanan/AFP/Getty Images

Another SNP victory in the Scottish election, another set of heads buried in the sand in Westminster. Despite the highest ever number of pro-independence MSP's now sitting in Holyrood, and the humiliation of the establishment British parties, independence seems further away than ever. Sure, we passed a motion asking nicely for the British government to give Scotland the power to hold our own referendums, but, unsurprisingly, nothing came from it.

Since then, these parliamentary parties have been noticeably silent on the recent Westminster meddling in our legally independent justice system. When the British government asked supreme court judge Lord Young to suspend our case into the illegal proscription of Palestine Action, he gladly obliged and waited for the English courts to finish their appeal.

A spokesperson from Scottish Palestine Solidarity Campaign put it well: "They dismissed the experiences of Scots arrested as irrelevant to the public interest and that the court should defer its jurisdiction to its English equivalent. Telling every Scot to just sit and wait for England to decide for us." Now that Westminster has overturned the ruling that proscription was illegal, we can expect to see our courts brought to heel.

To many, this is awfully familiar. The last time our supposedly devolved Scottish state took action that the British government didn't like (i.e. passing the gender recognition act with over a 2/3rds majority), the devolution act was used to undemocratically block its assent into law. Before this, the 'Indyref2' court case in 2022 found that it is the British government that gets to make decisions about the future of Scotland, not us.

Both of these defeats severely undermined Sturgeon's position as first minister, and its clear Swinney learnt his lesson, he's safer pretending to stand up for Scotland rather than fighting for us. The SNP has now become the most useful tool of British interests in Scotland. They are trying to pull the Saltire over our eyes so we cannot see that British and American capitalists continue to plunder our land and grind down our people. The only vision they can show us is exchanging the British capitalist for European ones, and their only strategy to advance independence is one where we keep voting for them. No matter what disasters they bring to education, the NHS, the homelessness crisis, violence against women, the drugs epidemic, the self-described institutionally racist police, the cost of living, or the housing crisis, republicans and nationalists are told to put everything that matters in our daily lives to the side for the sake of building another election mandate the British state won't care about.

Shit will continue to get worse for as long as we believe the lie that any parliamentary political party has an interest in the people other than in our votes. We almost had independence back in 2014, but it was working class volunteers and activists wading knee deep through Tory and Labour lies to chap on doors that brought us to the brink, not Holyrood.

What happened when the voting was over? The SNP dominated leadership of the YES Scotland campaign allowed our massive working-class movement to fizzle out and fracture once again into disorganisation (not to mention the alleged missing £1.5 million in campaign funds). There is a trend here as well for the SNP. This recent election, they claimed that only an SNP majority would win their mandate for referendum, despite the growing power of the Scottish Greens. They continue to put themselves above the movement, to everyone's detriment.

Who then should lead the movement for our independent republic? The Greens are under the same incentives as the SNP, if they rose to the top we'd be hearing the same stories for the next twenty years, and all the while the rising far right in Westminster would continue to demolish what little safety and quality of life remains. If it was the working class volunteers that have remained steadfast in the struggle while our leaders in parliament beat a sneaky retreat, then why not us? A movement for independence under working class leadership would ensure that independence is for the working class, not for Scottish or EU elites. We could weather the storm of parliamentary politics far better than those spinning within it, and through building a strong and honest working class movement we can quit asking the king and his servants for independence and take it ourselves.

‘If politics inherently refers to decision-making that affects others,



then these decisions must have an enforcement mechanism to exist in the material world’

The Iran War in Political Perspective: *The Context*



Image of Al Aqsa Flood, October 7, 2023.

An introduction to the empire and its enemies

Regardless of who one asks, it seems clear that the post-Cold War US Empire's political and economic dominance is waning domestically and internationally. Of course, Glasgow is no stranger to imperial decline; once a beating industrial heart and known as the "Second City of the British Empire", now is scarred by deep economic inequality, every third child living in poverty, viciously parasitic landlords, an unfit-for-purpose and extortionate public transport system, an exceptionally low average life expectancy compared even to the rest of Scotland, a deeply corrupt and ineffective City Council, and an emboldened far right presence which is being positioned to reinforce the rule of the bosses as conditions worsen without a coherent political alternative.

Empires across history have required specific conditions to collapse; at the minimum, an inability for the ruling class to economically sustain their own status quo combined with internal and external resistance. The end of the British Empire following WW2 was an aberration where this did not happen simply because the US simply took over the reins of the Empire, subordinating the British State's weakened economy into dependence on the US economy with the Marshall Plan and the Bretton Woods system, paving the economic foundation of the new 'special relationship'. Following British imperialism's failure in the Tripartite Aggression/Suez Crisis in 1956, the US also took over its geopolitical role as policeman of the world.

The relatively newborn and isolated Zionist occupation of Palestine (aka, the Zionist entity or "Israel"), was forced out of Egypt during the Tripartite Aggression but it achieved an overwhelming military victory over the armies of the Arab states in 1967, including over Nasser's Arab Republican Egypt, leading to a crisis of faith in Arab states and ordinary people taking resistance to Zionism into their own hands. This led to the rise of secular and communist resistance movements after 1967, based on popular mobilisation around a shared dream for a socialist pan-Arab republic that would liberate Palestine. Over the course of the next decades, these movements either sold out/normalised with the Zionist entity (implicitly accepting imperialist domination of their countries) or their tactics did not evolve sufficiently to keep up with the entity's tactics, leading to the people turning towards Islamic resistance movements, such as Hamas and Hezbollah, who had fresh ideas and an unbroken willingness to resist. After all, political participation in any group is based around 2 fundamentally interconnected motivations; firstly, the need for community in facing problems larger than any individual and secondly, demonstration of the group's political effectiveness against said problems.

These Islamic resistance movements found a state who closely aligned with both their Islamic values and material circumstances in opposing the US Empire (and its Zionist extension); the newly created Islamic Republic of Iran formed by the 1979 Iranian Revolution. According to an estimate by the US Department of State in 2020, the Islamic Republic consistently donates \$100 million annually to Palestinian resistance groups, with the actual level of support in military supply lines and technical expertise likely being even more valuable. Compared to US military aid, this support is not predicated on becoming puppets/proxies and has come at an immense economic cost to Iran (due to sanctions/economic warfare) that is far larger than any minor direct military benefit Iran receives in return. 1 This support for Palestinian resistance (including for secular resistance movements pre-1990s) has immense grassroots support within Iran, despite many contradictions within Iranian society and the Iranian government; many of these factors will be explored in future articles in this series on Iran.

War and politics: a primer from Clausewitz

At time of writing, the fragile ceasefire agreement (known as the 'Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding', or MoU for short) that the US/Zionist entity were forced to accept after launching their war of aggression against the Islamic Republic of Iran over 4 months ago, has ended due to US military violations of the ceasefire on 12/07/2026. Although the ceasefire was temporarily put in danger of ending previously due to Zionist aggression in Lebanon, this time official statements by the Iranian Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) suggest that full hostilities have resumed against US military bases in the region and the Strait of Hormuz shipping lane has again been fully closed by military blockade.

We can observe that the previous MoU contained historically unprecedented concessions to Iran and unless the US can achieve new political objectives with the current round of aggression, it is likely that even more favourable terms for Iran will be included in the next ceasefire agreement. As anti-imperialists, there is much to learn from how Iran are achieving these results despite facing overwhelming odds, with this series of articles aiming to explore how Iran's strategy played out, what contradictions remain, and what implications this has for the US Empire's future going forwards. This article will begin with an overview of the relationship between war and politics, then give a basic context for the geopolitical role of the Zionist entity in South-West Asia, and how al-Aqsa Flood/October 7th has changed the political and military landscape leading up to the current war. To begin this exploration, we should have a baseline shared understanding of the relationship between war and politics. Carl von Clausewitz, a Prussian general and military theorist, famously wrote that "war is a mere continuation of politics by other means".¹

We can define 'politics' as any decision-making that affects any others in any way; from the more personal decisions of distributing housework with those you live with to the massive international impacts of large superpowers making decisions and everything in-between, all of this is 'political'. Helpfully, Clausewitz defines war as "an act of violence intended to compel our opponent to fulfill our will [...] Violence, that is to say, physical force (for there is no moral force without the conception of States and Law), is therefore the means; the compulsory submission of the enemy to our will is the ultimate object. In order to attain this object fully, the enemy must be disarmed, and disarmament becomes therefore the immediate object of hostilities in theory."²

If politics inherently refers to decision-making that affects others, then these decisions must have an enforcement mechanism to exist in the material world. This enforcement mechanism may not directly require physical force but the use of force is certainly not outwith this process (instead, all enforcement mechanisms lie on a spectrum of "compulsion"). Arms, in this abstract sense, means anything that allows a group to resist the "compulsory submission to a will" within politics/war. This has important implications on how we understand arms in class "warfare"; a trade union, if and only if it fulfills its function of resisting the compulsory submission to the will of the bosses, is armament, and "disarmament becomes the immediate object of hostilities" for bosses in response. Bringing it back to the recent US-Zionist entity war of aggression against the Islamic Republic of Iran, Clausewitz gives us the framework that allows us to cut through the chaos and confusion that always surrounds such high-stakes endeavours such as war (also known as the 'fog of war'). We need to understand what the political will of the US Empire is in South-West Asia (also known as the Middle East) overall, how they attempted to use physical force to compulsorily submit Iran to this will, and how Iran avoided disarmament and even forced the US to submit to their will in various circumstances instead.

¹ US military aid is often conditional on allowing US military bases to be built on strategically valuable land, with deployed soldiers and weapons being completely unaccountable to local laws and customs. For an infamous example, see the 22

Visiting Forces Agreement between the US and the Filipino government.

² Full quote can be found in "On War" by Clausewitz, Book 1, Chapter 1.



The flood draws blood

The primary aim of US imperialism in South-West Asia since 2023 has been to stave off the existential danger to the Zionist entity that al-Aqsa Flood ("October 7") initiated. Previously, the Palestinian masses were already approaching a boiling point, with the entity brutally suppressing mass protests (e.g., the 2018 Great March of Return in Gaza) and accelerating settler invasions of the West Bank and al-Quds/Jerusalem (e.g., the 2021 planned ethnic cleansing of 6 Palestinian families in Sheikh Jarrah, East al-Quds). It is a fundamental aspect of human nature to defend oneself against injustice but when the scale of the injustice involves an occupation army with state of the art weapons, a 16 years full land, sea and air military blockade, and no right to even express your discontent "peacefully", is it any surprise that the Resistance patiently developed such an impressive counter-offensive as al-Aqsa Flood to finally strike back at the occupation? Forcing the settler forces to enter Gaza, crawling street by street over a meticulously prepared tunnel network which the Resistance have prepared their entire lives to defend, in one of the most densely populated areas on Earth, was all calculated to maximize the losses of the occupation and drag them into a regional war that would stretch their resources thin while aiming to inspire mass resistance to imperialism across the region and the world. Al-Aqsa Flood's closest historical equivalent would be the Battle of Stalingrad, where the invading Nazi German forces were forced into a urban quagmire which was bitterly defended street by street by soldiers and civilians against a far technologically superior force until the momentum of the invasion was broken, beginning the turn of the tide of World War 2.

Up till that fateful day in October, the entity's military doctrine was based around the sadistic "Dahieh Doctrine", also commonly referred to as "deterrence". The doctrine, named after the heavy bombardment of the Dahieh neighbourhood in Beirut in 2006 - due to the people there being predominately Shi'ia and hence being Hezbollah's popular base - was based around deterring long term, low-grade attritional warfare (which suits asymmetric guerilla groups like Hezbollah) by using massive, disproportionate force on pro-Resistance civilian targets (this is known as "countervalue" targeting rather than military/"counterforce" targeting). To quote an IOF ("Israeli" Occupation Forces) commander summarising their doctrine in 2008:

"What happened in the Dahieh quarter of Beirut in 2006 will happen in every village from which shots will be fired in the direction of Israel. We will wield disproportionate power and cause immense damage and destruction. From our perspective, these are military bases. [...] Hezbollah understands well that its fire from within villages will lead to their destruction. Before Nasrallah gives the order to fire at Israel, he will need to think 30 times if he wants to destroy his support base in the villages. This is not a theoretical matter for him. The possibility of harm to the population is the main factor restraining Nasrallah, and the reason for the quiet in the last two years."

This doctrine reflects the nature of asymmetric warfare; the side with state resources (and in this case, international support from the world's most powerful economy and military) is often the side who has the most resources to waste on countervalue targets. This often generates more support for the guerillas/insurgency, ironically leading to them spending more resources on an increased and more determined pool of counterforce targets in the long-term. On the other hand, a guerilla force cannot waste significant resources on countervalue targets unless it fits into a wider strategy or it has other cascading effects on counterforce targets; we can use this to explain a key regional pattern where the entity seems to constantly push for disproportionately risky invasions into South Lebanon against Hezbollah over fairly low-intensity rocket fire towards settler outposts in the north of occupied Palestine (which borders Lebanon).

This regular attritional rocket fire has cascading counterforce effects because the entity is fairly unique as a military force due to 3 main factors; firstly, the overwhelming support of settlers for the occupation forces; secondly, the continuous implementation of conscription meaning the line between counterforce and countervalue targets is extremely thin; and thirdly and most importantly, the Zionist settler colony is dependent on continuous recruitment of more Jewish settlers from across the world and if these new settlers are forced to live under constant bombardment, they are unlikely to remain leading to these settlements eventually collapsing from migration-induced population losses. This leads to less settlements, meaning more concentrated rocket fire, meaning less wasted resources and increased effectiveness per rocket, meaning accelerated settler migration from the north, making IOF movements easier to track and forcing settler soldiers less familiar with the north of occupied Palestine to take up posts against Hezbollah, making counterforce targets more likely to be struck, creating a loop of positive feedback that ends with the withdrawal of entity forces and settlements from Lebanon (which fulfils one of Hezbollah's primary purposes, being to defend the Lebanese people from the Zionist entity).

"Deterrence" has been shattered completely by al-Aqsa Flood since it broke the prestige of the IOF (which has never been defeated in any large scale conflict within the borders of occupied Palestine until that moment), proving that even seemingly "deterred" resistance groups like Hamas, which had only conducted low-intensity attritional rocket fire (with far less sophisticated explosives than what Hezbollah has access to, given their far easier access to Iran's supply network) with occasional higher-intensity bursts of rocket fire at symbolic moments, could actually inflict serious counterforce damage to the IOF and could have broken the blockade of Gaza at any time despite a massive disparity in firepower and numbers. Fortunately for the entity, the complicity of the surrounding Arab states (most significantly Egypt for Gaza but also Jordan for the West Bank) provides key logistical and political assistance to the entity's increasingly fragile grip on power. 3 Hamas also tied the hands of the IOF in the eyes of the world by taking settlers hostage, which the entity still had little qualms sacrificing (with this "principle" of eliminating hostages to deny leverage being known as the Hannibal Directive) but this tactic was more effective due to Hamas' conscious awareness of the condition of the hostages accelerating internal divisions within the entity's settler population and attracting massive international attention (similar to the Vietnamese military/media strategy around the Tet Offensive).

It is within this chain of events which leads to increasingly desperate and unhinged Zionist aggressions against Iran, provoking Iran's first direct military response to "israel", which eventually escalates to the current war with the full force of the US Empire bearing down on the Islamic Republic of Iran and its people, and its resultant global consequences. However, readers will have to pick up the next issue for more details on Iran's first responses to the entity, the principles and tactics of asymmetric warfare used by Iran to strike well-protected counterforce targets, impose disproportionate costs on a technologically superior enemy, mitigate the enemy's strengths in air superiority, and the political lessons we can take from these observations.

3 All of the Palestinian Resistance factions have repeatedly condemned Arab states for failing to uphold their moral and spiritual obligations to Palestine and called for the Arab, Muslim and international masses to support them in their struggle.



The Lebanese State Surrender Agreement



US imperialism and its extension "Israel" alongside their partners of the British State, the EU, the Gulf states and the Turkish state, have been attempting to reshape South-West Asia into the so-called "New Middle East". This plan of US imperialism has two main streams: 1) diplomatic normalisation between the Gulf states and "Israel"; 2) regime change of countries in opposition to US imperialism, most successfully carried out in Syria, with their newly established fanatically sectarian pro-US government.

The war that the US finds itself entangled in against Iran has called for tactical reconsiderations. As the Iranian people decisively rejected the regime change through rallying around their government, the US has been put in a position where it has to more forcefully assert its demands and control across the wider region. We will focus on the historic betrayal of the Lebanese state exemplified by the trilateral agreement signed with the US and "Israel" in June this year.

US imperialism has a vested interest in restarting the Lebanese civil war and the government in Lebanon seems more than eager to support its mission. In the lead up to this agreement, there has been a push to reignite sectarian divisions, with attempts by Zionists and collaborator Lebanese to sow division among Lebanese people, particularly with those in the South who are majority Shi'i and tend to be far poorer. This division comes with these forces to build ties between secular and Christian Lebanese with "Israelis". This is very dangerous territory as the Christian fascist and supremacist Kataeb Party, who were strong allies of "Israel" during the Zionist invasion of Lebanon in the 80s, are still around and seek to profit from this. Many Christians in Lebanon oppose these schemes, with many churches coming out against these attempts at normalisation of Zionism.

The most concerning points of this agreement relate to foreign military intervention in Lebanon in the state's attempt at disarming Hezbollah. Point four of the agreement explicitly lays out that the Lebanese government "requests the support of international and particularly Arab partners, under the leadership of the United States, to achieve this outcome." We are fortunate that the US is so open about their role here as this clarifies which "Arab partners" this could be. It might be the Saudi government, whose invasion of Yemen led to an ongoing ten-year famine, or the new Syrian government, run by former al-Qaeda leader Ahmed al-Jolani, that is now carrying out pogroms of ethnic and religious minorities across the country.



The Lebanese state has made itself into a fully compliant servant of imperialism as it's desire to disarm Hezbollah fits exactly into US and Zionist plans for the region. Currently, Hezbollah is the only force in Lebanon that is defending the sovereignty of the nation and fighting against "israeli" occupation in the South. To attempt to disarm them when Lebanese land is still under occupation is a wholehearted readiness to sell out the whole country.

However, subjugating Lebanon to reactionary Arab states is not enough. The Lebanese state continues to throw the South under the bus. The agreement legitimises "israeli" occupation forces (IOF) presence in South Lebanon under the pretext of gradual redeployment. Of course right after the agreement went public, plenty of "israeli" government ministers came out saying that the IOF is not going anywhere anytime soon. Clearly the last 75 years of the Zionist state constantly breaking any international and local agreement makes them a very trustworthy partner!

While the Lebanese state calls for an occupation of its own country under the pretext of "Lebanon first", Iran continues to place Lebanese's sovereignty as a cornerstone of any ceasefire with the US, whereas Hezbollah continues to defend the land and the people as best as they can.

Even if the Lebanese state got its way, the people of Lebanon have always resisted occupation, whether Syrian, French, American or "israeli" – and they have always won.



